



1. DR PUSHKAR DRAVID, 25

Indore

He took the NEET in 2015 and qualified for a seat in a private medical college where the fee would work out to Rs 5-6 lakh annually. Through a career counsellor, he learned about South Western University in Sebu in the Philippines, where the cost was Rs 2 lakh annually. He was back in India in 2021 and cleared the FMGE in December.

2. ARSHPREET KAUR, 21

Chhindwara

This second-year student of medicine at the Uzhhorod National Medical University in west Ukraine was among the 18,000 students evacuated after Russia's invasion. Back in her hometown, Arshpreet wonders if she'll ever be able to finish her degree.

availability of human resources for health, according to the WHO.

In a country with the world's highest rates of death from treatable diseases like diarrhoea, tuberculosis and pneumonia, the dearth of doctors is inexcusable. The regional disparity makes it worse. Four states—Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and Maharashtra—account for 45.5 per cent of the doctors in India even though they constitute only 24 per cent of India's population. And 47 per cent of India's 703 districts don't have a single medical college.

In his paper, 'Aggregate Availability of Doctors in India: 2014–2030', Basant Potnuru, an associate professor of Economics and Business Policy at the FORE School of Management in Delhi, calculates that to reach the doctor-population ratio of 10:10000 by 2030, India will need to have two million doctors by then. This means we need to produce over one million additional active doctors *annually* till 2030, after accounting for doctors who have retired or emigrated.

Given the magnitude of the crisis, the Union government's ambitious plan to establish 157 new medical colleges in three phases (58+24+75), launched in 2014, 2018 and 2019, at an estimated cost of Rs 24,735 crore, to produce 15,700 additional medical graduates annually, appears grossly looks inadequate. The final goal is to set up at least one medical college for every three districts and generate an additional 100,000 MBBS seats by 2025.

Going by the pace of work in the past six years, achieving this target within deadline seems ambitious. Till December 10, 2021, only 70 of the 157 newly planned medical colleges had become functional, as the Union health ministry revealed in the Lok Sabha. Till July 2021, only six of the 22 AIIMS announced since 2014 had become fully functional while MBBS classes had commenced in 12 others.

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NEW MEDICAL COLLEGES ADDED IN THE PAST 6 YEARS, 136 OF THEM IN THE GOVERNMENT SECTOR

WHERE ARE THE TEACHERS?

Infrastructural delay in getting hospitals up and running is the easier part of the challenge in the government as well as the private sector. The tougher ask is getting faculty to teach, especially in government colleges. Even the country's most prestigious medical college—the All